excruciatingly elaborate and time-consuming, leading to delays in production and increased costs.

In view of the governmental restrictions, Sumant Moolgaokar, the vice-chairman of Tata Motors and Tata Steel, had advised that TISCO should also have growth shops of the kind that he had started in TELCO. There was a critical requirement for ‘machining, fabrication, designing and building’, in TISCO, recalled Syamal Gupta, the chief development engineer of the steel plant from 1965 to 1966.

Some of these growth shops were established in TISCO. The process enormously benefited from the plans Ratan had made for redesigning and revamping the structural workshops. These shops led to faster replacement of parts and equipment at a fraction of the cost of imported equipment, resulting in increased efficiency, productivity and profits.

Lady Tata Passes Away

By the middle of 1965, Lady Tata’s health took a turn for the worse and Ratan became fearful. On the morning of Friday, 20 August, emergency calls came one after the other, asking him to rush to Bombay. To get to the city, he would have had to go by road to Ranchi, the nearest airport, five hours away. He would then have to fly to Hyderabad as there were no direct flights from Ranchi to Bombay, and then take a flight to Bombay. Ratan frantically searched for a commercial flight to Hyderabad, but there was none. He then rushed to Sir Jehangir Ghandy, the director-in-charge of TISCO, who was scheduled to fly to Hyderabad in the company plane. He informed Sir Jehangir that his grandmother was critical, and he would like to get a ride with the director. Sir Jehangir readily agreed, and after dropping him at Hyderabad, Ratan flew in the same aircraft to Bombay. It was the first time that he had taken the company aircraft to Bombay all by himself.

Ratan landed in the early afternoon and rushed to Tata House. As Lady Tata had refused to be admitted to any hospital, she was at home, waiting for him.

As he reached her bedside, Ratan recalls, ‘she held my hand’. They spent nearly four hours together. For almost three of those hours, she was talking to him. As the clock struck seven in the evening, she could speak no more, but her gaze was still fixed on him. ‘She looked at me and when she